

The Third Noble Truth - The End of Unsatisfactoriness

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So I thought this evening to talk a little bit about the third noble truth, the cessation of *dukkha*.

From the Vipassanā guidelines that we were reading, the very last is some description of this, the goal of our path, the cessation of suffering, *Nibbāna*. And it goes, "There is the unborn, the undying, the uncreated, the unconditioned, refuge, harbour, home, perfect contentment and peace."

It's just interesting to reflect on that. There are some beautiful analogies: refuge, harbour, home, perfect contentment and peace. But then, of course, there's the unborn, the undying, the uncreated, the unconditioned. That can stir confusion to some extent. What does that all mean?

I think the main thing is just to be aware of what any reflections of *Nibbāna* actually bring up in you. Just let the reflection of *Nibbāna* bring up whatever it brings up, whether it's peace and inspiration, whether it's confusion and frustration. Just allow that to be recognised, to be noted, and then we're on the path to *Nibbāna*, and we'll find out eventually what it actually is all about.

In the main, the Buddha didn't speak much about *Nibbāna*, but just the path to *Nibbāna*. And that's our focus too, to really work out how do we stop suffering rather than spend a lot of time trying to work out what is it that we're aiming for? What exactly is it? What is the unconditioned?

However, there is some value in also spending some time trying to clarify what the goal is. So Joseph Goldstein, for example, uses the analogy of walking through the woods at night. He wanted to get through the woods at night to get to his home. The fact that he knew that his home was in that direction gave him the motivation, the stimulus, the energy, the wish to walk through the woods. So he could stop and reflect on that in order to get through the woods if he got a bit dejected. But if he was just to look ahead and try to see his house at the other side of the woods, then he'd probably stumble and fall and just cause himself trouble.

In the same way we can stop every now and again and just reflect on *Nibbāna* for some energy, for some stimulus to our path. But the main task is then to let go of all that and just this moment. Like him looking down at his feet, take this step safely. We let go of the possible future, whatever it is, and we come back to the here and now and let our practice lead us to *Nibbāna*.

I think one way we can gain confidence that *Nibbāna* is actually a very worthy goal is that as we do our practice, we do see how it brings out the best in us and how it lets go of some level of stress and suffering

in our lives. So we can more and more trust that where we're going is actually a very worthy place.

So some words the Buddha did use to describe it. One was the end of *dukkha*. That's the most common description of *Nibbāna*, the end of all sense of dissatisfaction or stress or suffering of any kind. So *dukkha* does not apply there. He called it unshakeable bliss and another term was everlasting.

In that sense, everlasting, we see that transience doesn't apply, *anicca* doesn't apply. So *Nibbāna* isn't a changing state, like everything changing in this universe, that keeps slipping through our fingers. *Nibbāna* is unchanging, everlasting. So *dukkha* and *anicca* do not apply, but that third characteristic that we've talked about, *anattā* or not-self—it's arguable, and scholars do argue, but a lot of them would say that *anattā* does apply.

Anattā does apply to *Nibbāna*, in the sense that if there's a self, we're always trying to control things and manipulate things and hold them to ourselves. So whenever we get to *Nibbāna*, we won't be able to hold it for ourselves. There'd be no wish even to hold it for ourselves. It's not graspable, and we won't even want to grasp at it. The self brings about boundaries and limits and defensiveness and everything like that. So *Nibbāna* is without boundary, without limit.

In that sense, one way the Buddha described it is, he said, "*Nibbāna* exists, but not the one who enters it." Which is a nice way to put it. *Nibbāna* exists, but not the one who enters it. Again, something to reflect on.

Another way of stating that would be that *Nibbāna* is the reality of non-grasping. As we said, the self gets created to grasp onto some desire. That's happening all through our lives. Something pleasant stimulates our senses and we feel the desire and then a sense of self gets created in order to grasp onto that and try to hold it and make it mine. So our practice is always to relax, to let go as much as we can.

We can get little moments ourselves. We can tune in to little, you could call them temporary *Nibbānas*. We can get tastes of the state of not grasping. When a desire fades away. It's a very subtle moment, so we don't always tune into it, but it's really worthwhile beginning to tune in to that sense of the ending of a desire. You might notice there's actually no sense of me or mine at that moment. There isn't a sense of stress. There isn't a sense of anything to defend. So it really is worth beginning to tune in to these little moments, very momentary.

We often just don't notice them at all and let the next desire come up very quickly. But the more we tune in and notice them, we'll be so interested in them that the next desire won't come up quite so quickly. So every time desire fades, we do get a little momentary taste of the peace of *Nibbāna*.

Now, it's a very quiet happiness. It doesn't call our attention. I think that's why we miss it. We said those who are mindful are in the presence of *Nibbāna*. So *Nibbāna* is always present, but we actually just don't notice it. We don't tune into it. And that's really because it is so subtle. It's so quiet that our minds are designed really to tune into drama. As we've been talking about, for survival, we need to find out where the danger is. We need to find out where the good stuff is for survival. So our minds are attuned to the

dramatic, the loud, the colourful, the difficult. And our minds don't naturally tune into what's unobtrusive, what's quiet, what's not a threat.

So it takes a lot of practice for us to begin to sense those little unobtrusive, non-dramatic moments where there's no big storyline going on, there's nothing to take home out of this, there's no big success on offer to us. Those moments are actually really worth tuning into. We have to persuade ourselves of that, I think. We're so goal-orientated. We want spiritual progress and we have a sense that there will be a big cheer when we get to *Nibbāna*. And there'll be great delight and everything. But the fact of the quiet, subtle, unobtrusive little moments—it doesn't stimulate us in our culture to be looking for something unobtrusive, something you can't say anything about, something you can't tell your friends much about. It's not like a prize that we tend to value in our culture, quietness and subtlety.

So we really have to train ourselves to tune into quietness, to actually feel the value of it, to feel the immense peace that's on offer. And in those very quiet and unobtrusive moments, the mind easily wanders. That's what I've always found, is that we begin to lose interest as we get closer and closer to that quietness. The mind starts making up all kinds of little stories. It's funny, it nearly goes delirious sometimes. It just makes up stories about anything and everything. So again, we just have to be patient with all of that. It's just our minds not recognising value and going into some sort of a spin.

Now the Buddha did describe *Nibbāna* as subtle and at first he thought this state is so subtle that nobody—he didn't think anybody else in the world could actually pick up on it. He wasn't going to teach at first. So anyway we have to have a lot of patience. It does take time for subtlety to persuade us of its value and to even persuade us that it's there.

I remember one teacher saying that the first time that she really noticed calm, her noting word had a little question mark on it. It was, calm? calm? She couldn't believe that there was calmness. We really can disbelieve and not trust and deny calmness. Possibly we're embarrassed because it's always been there. So there's something in our mind that says, oh my God, I've been overlooking something. So there's all that embarrassment about having made a mistake. So we screen out the calmness that is always there.

There'll be all kinds of obstacles to noticing calm and subtlety, but the more we tune in, the more we'll have some sense of the goal of the path and the value of it.

Now, when the Buddha was talking about this world and *Nibbāna*, he often used the analogy of fire. So fire for this world of what's called *saṃsāra*, the opposite of *Nibbāna*. This world we live in, the round of greed, hatred, delusion. And then fire going out is often the analogy for *Nibbāna*, that moment when fire is extinguished.

The word *nibbāna* is actually used, I think even commonly in India today, for cooling. People say, "Will you *nibbāna* the rice?" So it's a cooling term. We have such lovely weather here this week that we can have a sense of the value of cooling. In our culture, sometimes cooling might not seem so great. But in India,

obviously, with their very hot climate, cooling is greatly valued. And fire, on the other hand, is aggressive, oppressive, threatening. So we have a sense of this world as oppressive, threatening, horrible, and then the ending of all of that, the relief when a fire goes out.

When the Buddha was enlightened, one quotation is that he surveyed the world with the eye of an awakened one. As he did so, he saw living beings burning with the many fevers and aflame with the many fires born of passion, aversion and delusions. So there's that sense that we are actually burning in our own fevers. We're burning in our own passions and aversion and delusion.

In the culture of India at the time, fire was thought to be trapped by its own fuel. So fire has to stay in the one place. It has to be a wood fire. It's trapped by the wood until the wood is all burnt out. It can be trapped by other things, grass and so on, and it's trapped there until the fuel is all burnt out.

In our case, then, the fuel is sense pleasure, wanting all the lovely stuff. And then views and opinions. We are very addicted to our views and opinions as well, how we love to be right and persuade others of our views and so on. So that's one of the fuels for keeping us here in *saṃsāra* is our very tight beliefs. And often we are quite afraid to examine our deepest beliefs and that would include the belief in self. That's a hard one for us to examine.

Now again, in India at the time of the Buddha, once the fuel was exhausted and the fire went out, the understanding was that the fire then was freed. And it existed then in a latent form, hidden but extending throughout the universe. So that's some sort of an analogy for us of the enlightened mind, the awakened mind, existing in a latent form, hidden but extending throughout the universe. So it's no longer in that stage bound to its fuel and unbinding is another term for *Nibbāna*.

Just a quotation relevant to that, at the death of the Buddha himself, one of his disciples, Aniruddha says, "Like a flame going out was the liberation of awareness." So the fire is freed. As the flame goes out, the fire is freed. We can't see it. We can't access it anymore ourselves directly. But the belief is that it's hidden and extending throughout the universe. So we have no way of knowing its whereabouts or quantifying it in any way. It's beyond our measuring, our reckoning.

So questions like, does the Buddha exist after death, just can't be answered. Because the Buddha's existence or non-existence after death is indescribable in our terms. There's a conversation between the Buddha and Upasīva about this. Upasīva is trying to get the Buddha to say, does the awakened person exist after death? He says, "There is nothing by which you can measure him. That by which he can be talked about is no longer there for him. You cannot say that he does not exist. When all ways of being, all phenomena are removed, all ways of description have also been removed."

So we have that mystery that it's not describable in our phenomenology. So that's probably a good point to end. *Nibbāna* is beyond description.

But just going back to the Joseph Goldstein analogy then of walking through the woods at night. To reflect

on *Nibbāna* can be useful. And it's worth asking, how do you feel? I often ask myself that. How do I feel when I reflect on these mysterious sayings? And often it does bring up hindrances because, the wish to know a little bit better, for me, might bring me into dullness or aversion of some description. The fact that this can't be actually put into words can be frustrating and so on.

So obviously it's the path. Just bear with all of those hindrances, just let them burn out. But what I always find is that once they have burned out, there's some new level of awareness where I'm seeing more beautiful qualities that little bit clearer. It could be peaceful sensations in the body. It could be emotions of kindness that I just hadn't really been able to access before.

I think the reflection on *Nibbāna*, no matter what it brings up, just allowing ourselves to sit with that will bring us towards *Nibbāna*. So I think that's a good point at which to end.

So we'll just sit for a while. Thank you.

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